



JESSE OWENS

James Cleveland Owens' family moved from Alabama to Cleveland to overcome the struggles of everyday life a little after he turned nine. Owens was already a workhorse of the poor family, picking 100 pounds of cotton every other day to help his mother put food on the table, despite being a frail child who was often sick, battling chronic bronchial congestion. The shift to Cleveland was a godsend for Owens, as he was able to attend a better school, which opened a chance to try his luck in athletics. But given the social conditions of the time and the lack of regular competition across all levels, it was a tough ride to the top for the American. True, the string of scintillating performances that Owens dished out in Berlin leading to an unprecedented four gold medals has often been portrayed as a big boost to the fight against racism as they took place under the close scrutiny of Adolf Hitler. But, for all the acclaim in the media, Owens was never met by his own country's president, and he was given only a backdoor entry to the bus that brought in all the winners. Later, as he gave up his amateur status, he was left to race against horses and cars to eke out a living. But true champions never say die and Owens found his calling in public relations, setting up business in Chicago.

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